

Matías Mattamala

Curriculum Vitae of Failures

OVERVIEW	This is inspired by the well-known CV of failures idea proposed by Prof. Melanie Stefan in a Nature article. I have summarised the main failures I remember but I am very aware there are others I did not even attempt. I generally try to put the eggs in different baskets <i>but I choose my baskets carefully</i>, so there are many things I considered for which I ended up not putting an application forward.
PHD PROGRAMMES	University of Oxford (2019) I failed to get into the CDT in Autonomous Intelligent Machines and Systems (AIMS), but I did get an offer from the normal Engineering Science programme (which ended up being the only PhD offer I received). Imperial College London (2019) I was rejected after passing two interviews. University of Edinburgh (2019) I intended it but I failed to put the application together and to arrange the recommendation letters before the deadline. ETH Zurich (2018) I was rejected during my initial enquiries. However, I managed to do a 6-months research stay with them in 2022 as part of my PhD. TU Delft (2018) I did not apply formally, but never heard back from my initial enquiries.
ACADEMIC POSITIONS	University of Edinburgh (2024) I applied for a lectureship in the School of Engineering, but I was not interviewed.
FELLOWSHIPS & GRANTS	Royal Academy of Engineering Fellowship (2026) UKRI Future Leaders Fellowship (2026) Applied with the University of Edinburgh. I was not interviewed by the School of Informatics' internal selection panel. The Eric and Wendy Schmidt AI in Science Postdoctoral Fellowship (2024) Applied with the University of Oxford. I was rejected before the interview step.
PUBLICATIONS	Wang et al. 'LT-Exosense: A Vision-centric Multi-session Mapping System for Lifelong Safe Navigation of Exoskeletons' This paper was rejected from RA-L, but it is available on ArXiv. Wang et al. 'Exosense: A Vision-Based Scene Understanding System For Exoskeletons' This paper was rejected from IROS 2024 but we addressed the main criticisms and re-submitted it to RA-L. It was accepted in 2025, and in 2026 it received a Honorable Mention. Kassab et al. 'The Bare Necessities: Designing Simple, Effective Open-Vocabulary Scene Graphs' This paper was rejected from CVPR 2024 and BMVC 2025. It is available on ArXiv and also a chapter of Christina's PhD thesis. Mattamala et al. 'Towards Visual-Odometric Monocular SLAM for Humanoid Robots' This was rejected from IROS 2018 and the Journal of Intelligent and Robotic Systems. It was never published, the contents are one chapter of my M.Sc thesis.

WORKSHOP
PROPOSALS

‘LocoLearn: From Bioinspired Gait Generation to Active Perception’

It was rejected from RSS 2024, but we got it into CoRL 2024.

OTHER

DARPA SubT Finals (2021)

I was involved in the competition as a PhD student in the Dynamic Robot Systems (DRS) group, which was part of the CERBERUS Team. CERBERUS made it to the final in the US, but DRS was not allowed to travel due to the strict COVID rules in the UK. CERBERUS ended up winning the challenge (but we will never know if it happened because we were not there).

RoboCup Standard Platform League (2012)

This was the first time I participated in the RoboCup and we got the last place in the SPL League.